EXPERTSPEAK

HOW LONG WILL THE WAR LAST?

Foreign policy analysts and former diplomats share their assessments on the possible duration of the US-Israel war on Iran and how it may come to an end. Here, they outline competing scenarios and starkly different expectations for the conflict's trajectory



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"We are flying blind"

It is very hard to predict how long the war will last since we have kicked the hornet's nest. The US is now in the territory of the law of unintended consequences. We are flying blind, captured by magical thinking. We have launched an entirely volitional and illegal war against a theocratic dictatorship whose leader the US military has now decapitated. He may be mourned by few, but may well be replaced by someone far worse. Iran is a country of 92 million people ruthlessly ruled for decades by a corrupt cabal of armed thugs. The Trump administration has no clue and plan for what comes next. The US must prepare for the likelihood of Iran's full implosion, fragmentation and the spread of chaos that would make the aftermath of our misadventures in Iraq and Libya look like a picnic.

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"Iran seeks to internationalise the conflict"

Tactical factors will determine how long this war will last, including the depth of Iran's missile inventory and the ability of the US and its partners to keep intercepting them. But there are strategic and political considerations as well. Iran's strategy is twofold. First, it's applying pressure on Trump's regional partners in the Gulf by going after their civilian and critical infrastructure, hoping to compel them to urge the US president to wind down the war quickly. In practice, this has pushed Gulf states closer to the US. Second, Iran also seeks to internationalise the conflict by imposing costs on the global economy, including by threatening shipping through the Strait of Hormuz. This too risks backfiring, with Britain and France already mobilising forces in the region. Ultimately, it's a question of which side has the political will to continue withstanding the effects of the war.

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schoolgirls and staff in Minab among them. Israel has admitted to losing 10 people and the US six servicemen. The war came home to India when three Indian crew members aboard two privately owned tankers were killed after missiles struck their ships in the Strait of Hormuz. On March 4, a US submarine torpedoed IRIS *Dena*, an Iranian warship that had taken part in a multinational exercise in the Indo-Pacific as a guest of the Indian Navy. Struck while returning to base, the vessel sank in the Indian Ocean, taking down 87 members of its crew.

Few conflicts in the modern Middle East have begun with so many unknowns. The opening strikes by the US and Israel intended to deliver a decisive shock not only to Iran's strategic capabilities but also to force a rapid political collapse in Tehran. Instead, as Stephanie T. Williams, senior fellow at the Center for Middle East Policy at Brookings in Washington D.C., puts it, the war has stirred a geopolitical "hornet's nest". As Iran responds with waves of missiles and drones and the conflict spills across the Gulf, Williams warns, "We are flying blind now and are in the territory of unintended consequences." With stock markets trembling across the world and countries bracing to face the